– Pakistan cricket?

A case in point is the controversy over the 'Big Three' issue where Pakistan cricket stood isolated in challenging the hegemony of Australia, England and India during the reforms debate a few years ago. Sure, the Big Three system is the staple now but the tale of our failure to challenge that arrangement – where the Big Three call the shots of how and where the game is played, globally, and decide who plays whom – is an obvious consequence of not just the PCB's internal managerial weaknesses but also the events in the buildup to that failure: the attack on the Sri Lankan team that choked off international cricket in Pakistan, the captaincy crisis in the team, the spot-fixing controversy and even the very real threat by the ICC that Pakistan cricket could be shut down for four or five years till the PCB puts our house in order.

Dealing with the Big Three under such circumstances has been difficult. Yet, it merely leads one to the conclusion that self-confidence in advocacy and an aggressive restructuring of the domestic and international game in Pakistan is the only way out for my country to regain its once-glorious cricketing status. Pakistan has to make itself strong again. Pakistan must rise back to the top of the field, the ratings regime and the decision-making table at the ICC.

Thankfully, the security situation in the country is getting better. Successful editions of the Pakistan Super League (PSL) have allayed fears that no foreign players would come to play in Pakistan because of security concerns. The October 2017 T20I game in Lahore, albeit with a watered-down Sri Lankan unit, partially changed that perspective. But aren't our local cricketers talented enough to bring a new energy and impetus to the game? Can they not be channelled, marketed, promoted and used correctly? There was a time when first-class cricket in Pakistan was followed widely. Why can't we take the key learnings from our local success stories and merge them with the current and best practices of the modern game today?

Till we don't get back our self-confidence, till we don't get the right people to market our cricket to our nation and rediscover the talent out there, not much will come of it. The proof is in the books. Marketing rights for a regular international series go for $150,000 to $200,000 today. Seriously? And this is supposed to be one of the greatest teams to have ever played all formats of the game?

I've had sponsors come to me and express amazement about how they came to the table with budgets of $700,000 or even a million dollars for a bilateral series, but the PCB was happy to undervalue the deal and sell it for peanuts. Is that fair to the game, to the audiences, to the players or to the team? No. And no, spot-fixing or match-fixing or player corruption has nothing to do with the problem of undervaluing and underselling Pakistan cricket. That is a serious shortcoming, shows a lack of ambition and is the fault of the people who run the PCB. This has happened under the tenure of not one, but several former chairmen. Also, to clarify: I'm not advocating greed here. I'm pushing for self-worth. If we want to catch up with the Big Three, then we must get the PCB and its finances in order as soon as possible. For that, we will have to get over our internal politics. Tall order.